

CAPSTONE ASSIGNMENT

Company: NS



Team number: 95

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1. Organisational Profile and structure

NS is one of the most visible companies in the Netherlands, facilitating over 1 million train journeys every day (NV Nederlandse Spoorwegen, 2025, p. 3). With staffing averaging 19.208 full time equivalents over the course of 2024 (NV Nederlandse Spoorwegen, 2025, p. 160) it can easily be described as a large company. Their financials confirm this, with 2024 revenue hitting 3.7 billion euros and a balance sheet of well over 6 billion euros in assets (NV Nederlandse Spoorwegen, 2025, p. 146, 148).

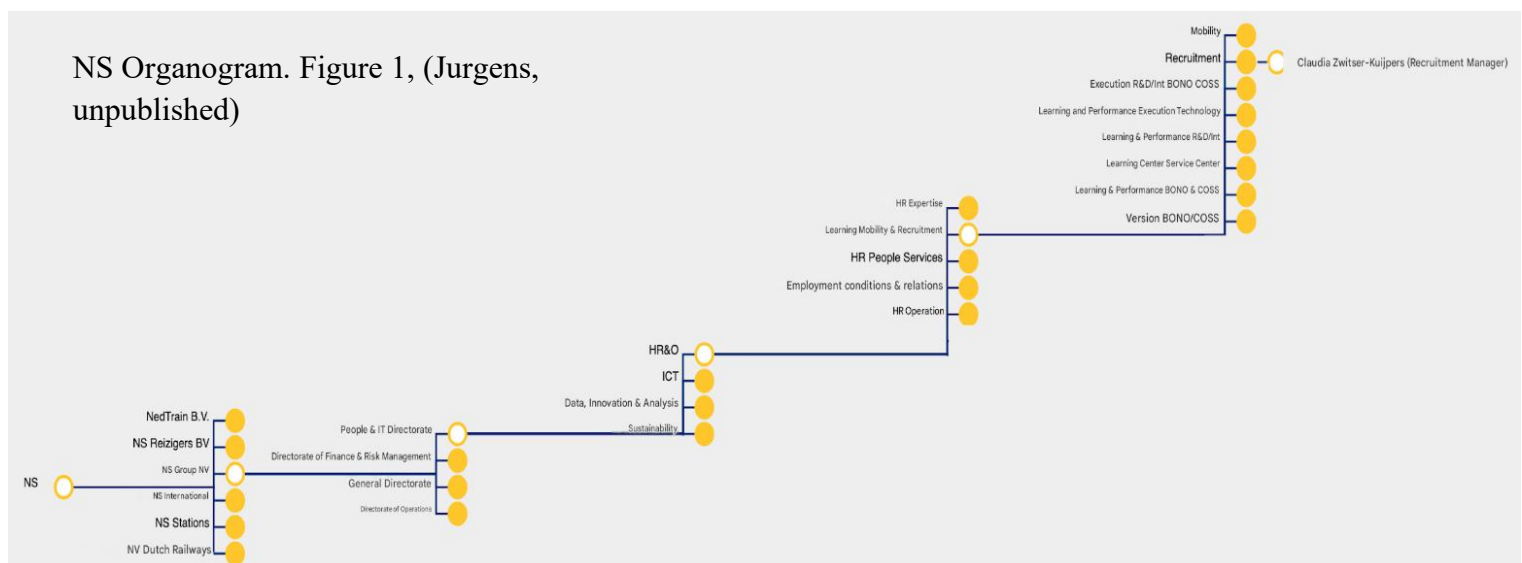
NS is divided into multiple different business units, with each unit having multiple departments. These business units all provide different services, but in the end, all products and services NS and its subsidiaries offer can be linked back to its main business: providing passenger rail transport and making it a more attractive option.

NS Reizigers, NS International and Abellio offer passenger rail transport. NS Stations offers facilities on stations, such as toilets, stores, parking and baggage lockers. Additionally, they operate OV-fiets, a public transport rental bicycle. NedTrain offers train maintenance to NS and other railway companies in the Netherlands. NS Groep NV offers services to all other business units, such as finance, human resources, IT and procurement. Table 1 provides a clear overview of all NS business units and their scope.

Our manager works in NS Groep NV, the business service provider for NS subsidiaries. Her department provides recruitment services to all NS's business units. This means they are in contact with every other business unit to serve their staffing needs. Her position within NS is highlighted in the organogram in figure 1.

Table 1: Main business units of NV Nederlandse Spoorwegen	Scope
NS Reizigers	Providing rail transport within the Netherlands
NS Internationaal	Providing international rail transport to and from the Netherlands
Abellio	Providing rail transport in liberalized rail markets outside of the Netherlands
NedTrain	Maintaining trains in the Netherlands, both for NS and competitors
NS Stations	Maintaining and developing railway stations in the Netherlands
NS Groep NV	Supporting other business units with business services

NS Organogram. Figure 1, (Jurgens, unpublished)





According to Business in Context (Needle & Burns, 2023) NS has adopted characteristics of the divisional organizational structure. NS is divided in several major business units like NS operations, commerce & development, NS stations and others. Each business unit functions semi-independently, has its own manager but sometimes has to cooperate with other units. NS has also some central functional departments including HR, IT and finance which provide shared services and strategic support to all divisions across the organisation. NS was privatised but is still fully owned by the Dutch government.

2. Manager

Claudia Zwitzer (49, female)

She started in a communications role at the Dutch Railway Museum in 2003. After 3 years she moved to NS Hispeed (now known as NS International) to an internal communications role. Later, she switched to a marketing communications role at NS Hispeed. In 2011 she moved to a project management role in NS Groep, still in communications. In 2017 she switched to being a team lead in a sales role. She stayed in various roles in sales as a team lead or product owner until 2020. In 2020 she became head of recruitment and employer branding at NS Groep. She still has this function to this day.

Our manager has worked from 2003 until the present day, thus a total of 22 years. She is responsible for a total of 80 subordinates and has 7 managers reporting directly to her.

3. Internal Challenge: Keeping the Team Motivated After Layoffs

The main challenge for the manager is keeping her team motivated and working well together after major staff cuts. The recruitment department has shrunk from 120 to 80 employees but is still expected to fill 5000 job openings a year. This has led to a stressful situation where the remaining staff have more work and feel less secure in their jobs. The manager acknowledged this, saying some employees are “afraid or insecure” and that everyone has to “work harder.” Although she tries to keep spirits high with fun activities, a core challenge is motivating a team that might fear their hard work won't protect them from future layoffs.

This problem can be explained with Vroom's Expectancy Theory, which says motivation depends on three things: believing your effort will lead to success (expectancy), believing success will lead to a reward (instrumentality), and wanting that reward (valence) (Mell, 2025, slide 6). The layoffs at NS have broken this chain. Expectancy is lower because the team may feel it's impossible to do the same amount of work with fewer people. More importantly, instrumentality is damaged because employees saw that at times, even good performance didn't save their colleagues jobs, so they no longer believe their hard work will be rewarded with job security. This makes their desire for job security (valence) unable to drive motivation. Additionally, Self-Determination Theory (Mell, 2025, slide 25) shows that while the manager's focus on team events helps with relatedness (feeling connected), the intense workload hurts their sense of autonomy (control) and competence (feeling effective), leaving key motivational needs unmet.

4. Recommendations for handling Internal Challenge

To solve this, the manager should focus on a strategy of empowerment through job enrichment and transparency. This strategy moves beyond social events to rebuild the team's confidence and motivation by addressing the core issues of trust, purpose, and control.

First, to fix the broken trust in rewards, the manager needs to practice targeted transparency. By clearly communicating how vital the team's work is for NS's future, she can help them believe their performance matters again. She should also publicly recognize employees for their great work, showing them that their efforts are seen and appreciated.

Second, to help the team feel their hard work can lead to success, she should enrich their jobs using ideas from the job characteristics model (Mell, 2025, slide 27). She can do this by increasing task significance, showing them the real-world impact of their hires and giving them more autonomy by letting them help redesign their own work processes to be more efficient. For example, to boost task significance, she could invite a newly hired train driver to a team meeting to share their experiences. To increase autonomy, she could empower a dedicated task force to redesign and streamline recruitment workflows, giving them direct ownership over solving the workload problem and making them feel like valued partners in navigating the challenge.

5. External Threat: A tight labour market

Next to the internal threats an organisation faces, external threats exist. Those external factors can originate from different kinds of environments. A large external factor that many companies, including NS, face is labour. They face increasing demands from employees. As a result, recruitment managers have a difficult time finding the suitable person for each job position.

Since the COVID-19 pandemic, the Dutch labour market has been increasingly tight, with labour demand rapidly outpacing supply. Even though labour market tightness is easing slightly, as seen in figure 2, it is still at historic heights. Until 2030 in most labour market segments, demand is expected to grow (Inia et al., 2024). According to Wester (2025), a report published by the Dutch labour market agency UWV, more than 50% of all job openings were hard to fill. This could partially be mitigated by increased labour market mobility in the EU, as mentioned in Needle & Burns (2023, p.142). Additionally, the Netherlands experiences high labour flexibility, with 37.7% of employees working part-time (Needle & Burns, 2023, p.138). Compared to other EU countries, relatively few part-time employees want to work more hours (Van Smoorenburg, 2025). This can further reinforce the tension in the labour market.



According to Swart et al. (2024), the Transport & Logistics sector has the highest share of employees aged 55+, with a total of 31%, with 40 to 50 percent of bus or tram drivers expected to retire in the next 12 years (Wester, 2024). By 2030 there will be an expected shortage of 20.000 (bus)drivers (Mobiliteit.nl, 2025), partially due to aging. Additionally, Youngworks (2021) claims young employees are leaving the mobility sector relatively quickly.

This tight labour market is a major cause of concern for the public transportation sector and contracting authorities such as local or national governments (Eg, 2023a). The staffing shortages related to labour market tightening are causing up to 10% busses, trams and trains to be cancelled, leading to a less reliable product and higher costs (Eg, 2023b). According to a report commissioned by the Dutch ministry of Infrastructure and Water Management (Boston Consulting Group, 2022), national rail operator NS had to operate using a scaled down schedule to manage staffing issues. In short, the current tight labour market is a major threat for the Dutch public transportation sector. This is in large part due to high turnover, both due to retirement and difficulties with retaining young employees. A labour shortage can have severe consequences for the public transportation sector, with service levels potentially being degraded According to the Business in Context model (Needle & Burns, 2023) this threat emerges from a combination of social (demographic ageing, changing workforce expectations) and economic (tight labour market, wage inflation) factors from the general environment.

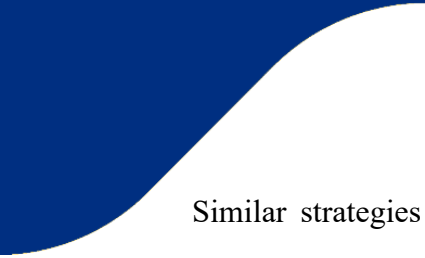
6. Recommendations for handling external threat

To cope with the tense labour market, organizations like NS must develop innovative and creative ideas to find new employees. Their strategy should focus both on recruitment and training newcomers. This way they can meet the requirements of the position they are hired for. The following recommendations can help mitigate the consequences of a tight labour market.

By enhancing the organization's Employer Value Proposition, the recruitment managers can achieve an increase of the people interested in being occupied in the organization. It is essential to attract the workforce's interest, and that can be achieved by convincing them that the specific organization is the ideal employer for them. Offering competitive compensation packages, flexible working hours and the opportunity for remote work fosters the attractiveness of the organisation as an employer.

Another way to deal with the employee shortage is adopting a strategic workforce planning approach. The organization should know for example how many of their occupants are going to retire in the next few years, or how many employment contracts are coming to an end. By having that knowledge the Human Resources Manager can recruit replacements before vacancies occur. That way the last-minute recruitment pressure is significantly reduced and the organization operates smoothly.

Finally, since it is often difficult to find candidates who already possess all the necessary competencies, the organization should focus on developing structured training programmes for upskilling new employees to meet job requirements. In addition, investing in skill-building courses for the already existing employees can reduce turnover and maintain the organization's workforce.



Similar strategies have been implemented successfully by international organizations. For instance, IBM (n.d.) reports that its HR department has implemented internal upskilling initiatives to develop existing employees and prepare them for future roles (IBM, n.d.)

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Appendix:

Students: So we're studying international business administration, which is like a management program. And for two different courses for Organizational Behavior and Introduction to Business, we have to do this assignment. So organizational behavior is mostly like, how do organizations work? How do you work with your employees? Like, how can you motivate people? Stuff like that. How do organizations work internally and business in context is mostly about the context of business. So the environmental factors, what are external things that influence the company? So we'll mainly focus on these things. For the intro we need two kinds of results. One is some managerial issue or challenge you're facing and the other is an external factor that is like an external threat to NS. Like external challenges. And we've prepared a few questions for that. So that's like a short summary of the assignment.

Manager: Seems a bit like, do you know the SWOT analysis?

Students: Yeah, I've heard of it. Yeah. Strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats.

Manager: Yeah, it's a bit like that.

Students: Exactly. So first we would like to ask you, what does your job look like? What do you do on a day to day basis?

Manager: Well, I'm head of recruitment and employer branding. And that means that with my, now 80 colleagues, I'm responsible to fill all the vacancies inside NS. So that's it.

Marketing, higher management, the people who work in the stations at the Kiosk and the Julia's, etc. And it's about 5,000 vacancies a year that we fill with each other. And I have a lot of colleagues on contract at NS, but I also have a flexible part. So now I have 80 colleagues.

But two years ago, when we needed in a few months 1500 new conductors and train drivers, I had 120 people here. So it's a bit fluid what I have.

Students: So do you work with external companies that can give you some recruiters?

Manager: No, independent contractors. Well, yeah, that's how I work. And the most beautiful thing in this job, I think, is that I have contact with all the company, all the parts of the company. So I see a lot of everything.

Manager: And what I do day to day. Well, it's also a company that's very focused on day to day business. Long term views are more difficult because every day we are responsible if the trains are driving and if there are enough people on trains and on stations etc. So it's a company that is faced with production, on day to day business. Do you understand what I mean?

Students: Yeah. Did you have any experience in HR management before this position?

Manager: No, before I was on the commercial side. I have a background in marketing. My experience now here on recruitment. I have had this position for 4 1/2 years because it's very needed as a marketing eye on. Because you're selling vacancies, that's what you're doing. It's marketing but not for a train ticket but on a vacancy.

Students: Yeah. Like that's the employer branding part of your job?

Manager: That's employer branding, yeah. So I also have 10 employer branding marketeers here on the floor to position and as a working place.

Students: To which extent do you feel like you're more of a human resources manager compared to more of a marketing manager?

Manager: Marketing manager I think yeah. We are part of HR recruitment, but it's another business than HR I think.

Students: What has been your educational background to get here?

Manager: Educational background?

Students: What have you done to get here educational wise?

Manager: Well, I think it doesn't really matter because my background is that I studied French at university and afterwards I studied communications. And I started first at a museum of Dutch Railways in a PR and communication role and then here marketing. I did marketing, I did sales, I did marketing, communications and then all of a sudden I started here and that also went well. So it just happened like that.

Students: How does your business unit contribute to the wider organization?

Manager: How does it contribute? Well, I think we're the front door of the whole company in fact. Yeah, yeah, they start with us. Everyone who is coming in. Yeah. We're the front door of all business units in fact that's how I see it.

Students: You said you have 80 subordinates, right? That's a pretty big team. Do you have any challenges like motivating your team or challenges that have to do with diversity that make your job more difficult?

Manager: I don't understand the question.

Students: I'm asking if you have in general any challenges with managing your team?

Manager: Difficulties with managing my team? No, it's okay. I'm focusing a lot on connecting, on the fun part, we are doing a lot of fun things. Because I believe that if that's the basis of a good working together, but also connecting and experience. These things are a

real recruitment experience. We are divided in six teams and all the teams are specialized in a part of the business. So there's one team who's only selecting conductors, train drivers and everything on the train. There's a team who's focused on the stations, the stores. We have a team that's focused on IT and technical jobs, etc. And they all do apart from each other fantastic things recruitment wise. But you have to make the mix as a manager like that all people like a whole team is excellating.

Students: Is it difficult to make the units collaborate with each other? Does sometimes one unit work on its own or do they always collaborate?

Manager: No, you have to organize that. You have to create spaces and meetings where they can show each other their success, but also their bloopers in an open environment. And yeah, that's going okay. And I think because on the other side we also focus on the fun part. So we are really often in the city or doing fun things with each other. So they also speak when something is going wrong in the business.

Students: I've heard some organizations have some issues with motivating their teams. But I see that you don't have that kind of problem, right?

Manager: No, no. And that's because I believe that you have to be an example to the rest of the organization. So we have a very diverse team. We also have people with a handicap like that or are coming from wherever and they're all working very strongly together.

Students: So the diversity hasn't been a problem for you?

Manager: No, no. But it's also because we are very much focused on that part that they are connected all the time.

Students: As you said, like doing fun things to connect people?

Manager: Yes.

Students: Okay. Yeah, it's so nice. Also, if you don't mind, I want to ask you some things about the general organization, not just your unit. Do all the units collaborate with each other for your desirable result?

Manager: If they all work like we are? Is that your question?

Students: Yeah. Not just the people that you're responsible for. Does the whole organization work together and do you have any trouble collaborating with other units? Do you work with different business units a lot?

Manager: Yes, all day.

Students: Do you feel like there are some culture differences or cooperating with some of them can be difficult, or do you feel like you mostly have the same vision and you can usually understand each other?

Manager: Yeah, in the basics we all have the same vision and the same DNA, but when it's getting exciting, then you see that if you talk to a department of marketing, that's a different world. Yeah, there are all different worlds and other way of communicating and acting and well, we are with 20,000 colleagues here, so everyone is acting differently. So that's the way it goes.

Students: Which external forces such as regulatory changes, economic shifts, socio cultural trends, technological advances, environmental considerations or legal developments are currently posing the greatest challenges or opportunities for the organization? So basically, what are the largest outside threats to it?

Manager: Yeah, in fact, everything where a company, a whole Holland is looking at NS. So you can't look in the paper or at the television, it's all about NS. And most of the time it's shit about ns. But the things that are the most hurting us, I think it's the polarization of a hard

economy. Yeah, that's the people. Another 12,000 people of us who are working in the stations or on the trains have a very hard time in violence in the train and discussion with travelers, etc. Most of the parts are in Amsterdam, Den Haag, Rotterdam, Utrecht. But that's a serious thing for us. Safety. I think that's the most serious threat for NS at the moment.

Students: What do you do to solve that problem? Have you taken any measures?

Manager: Well, maybe you have read in the media the pilot that we are taking in with body cams and the baton. Safety is a very big thing for us.

Students: And you have like 80 employees. So do you feel like you know most of them or is it hard to keep track of everybody that's coming in and leaving in such a large scene? Because you changed from 120 to 80 now.

Manager: Yeah, no, it's not hard because that's also because I believe that I have to have focus on that. That I know my colleagues and I know how I can make them happy. Because that's the only way I think that you can altogether fill those 5,000 vacancies a year. You have to bond with them because otherwise it's not possible in a normal way. For me it has to be hard working but also fun.

Students: Even though they don't necessarily report directly to you?

Manager: I know them.

Students: Yeah, yeah.

Manager: You know, I know them and I go to the bar with them. Yeah. Or to the movies or a karaoke or whatever. Yeah.

Students: So you go all together?

Manager: Yeah.

Students: Wow, that's nice.

Manager: Very important. And not always with all 80 people. But there are. None of them never come. So yeah.

Students: And NS has some financial difficulties. So like for office staff, there have been budget cuts, right?

Manager: Yeah.

Students: Have you experienced that in your department as well?

Manager: Yeah, immediately, because at this moment all the vacancies have to go to our board for an approval that they can be going out. So they're very on us. On us all that we don't spill money.

Students: Yeah. So you don't over hire.

Manager: No, not anymore.

Students: Okay, a few years ago you had 120 employees. Now you have 80. Is that also a consequence? More tight hiring?

Manager: Yeah. That's a consequence of this. Under the financial situation.

Students: Have you been able to retain everybody you wanted to?

Manager: Yes.

Students: So all the permanent or like semi permanent?

Manager: All the permanent. And all the people from whom you think with you and you and you. I'm gonna win this battle. Sure. That's the task of a manager that you have to fulfill and

you want to do that with the most, how do you say that? Dedicated people. That's it. The most dedicated people.

Students: How do you feel like your team has experienced those budget cuts? Like growing very quickly and then also shrinking pretty quickly after now.

Manager: To be honest, some of them are afraid or insecure about it, but I always also speak openly to them all. If we work well together, if you work hard or dedicated and have fun with us, then it's okay. I don't fire anyone like this, NS is too social. Therefore it's not a commercial company in this way.

Students: Sorry, I have one more question. The reduction of your employees from 120 to 80, did it have any consequences on the work you do?

Manager: You have to work harder. But you make or sometimes also when you are a recruiter of IT positions then we have to be creative and maybe I'll ask you also to do the technical positions or something completely different. You have to have an open mind because otherwise it isn't doable.

Students: With safety in like the stations and trains, would you say that the turnover of the employees is higher because of that? Like do they feel safe going to work or like some people leave because of that? Like because they don't feel safe?

Manager: Sometimes. Yeah. Sometimes you leave or they're going to see if there's another job at a company because they don't feel safe anymore. Yeah, that sometimes happens. It also sometimes happens with, maybe you're familiar with it, we also have the people who jump before the trains. That's one time a day. We have 350 a year. The people that die before the trains and that are also things that cause a lot of pain at train conductors and drivers.

Manager: And sometimes they leave then or there, whatever. Yeah, that's logical.

Students: But do you have a hard time finding new people for these positions or is it easy?

Manager: It's okay. It's easy. Yeah. There's a lot of people that want to be train conductors and drivers. It is an iconic job. So you have a lot of kids that at 4 years old or 3 years old saying 'I want to drive trains' and we have a lot of people who want to be that.

Students: Yeah. So on one hand like NS has been communicating to the media that they should really do more against violence with trained personnel. But on the other hand you from your employer branding has to communicate come to NS. It's a great place to work. Do you feel like that conflicts?

Manager: Sometimes. Yeah, sometimes that conflicts. So when something happens with our colleagues on the train and all the media are blown about it, then we get a lot of calls from people who are in the selection process that don't want to be anymore. But then 24 hours later it's all gone and everybody comes and wants to work here. So it's like this. But it has a direct effect on recruitment if something like that happens. Yeah, that's true.

Students: I also heard that you, besides your normal function, are taking over from some colleague or something. Or did I misunderstand?

Manager: I have. Yeah.

Students: Temporarily?

Manager: No, not temporarily. I have a second job. NS has a strategy, of course, and with several teams. And one of the teams is Gelijke Kansen. Equal opportunities for everybody. And I'm the owner of this team and well, it's my job now too. To bring that to life so that the country thinks: Okay. NS is a supporter of equal opportunities for everybody in transport and also in a workplace. There's a strategic job effect.

Students: And does it take a lot of your day?

Manager: Yeah, I think 50- 50. So okay.

Students: But before, how long have you been doing the equal opportunities part besides head of recruitment? When did the equal opportunities part come in?

Manager: Before summer. So it's now three–four months. And it's okay, because equal opportunities are also a part of recruitment. Of course, because equal opportunity starts with us, with who we are taking in. But then it's also a lot in the business and on the train, so that is extra. But I think now I've been head of recruitment for four and a half years, so that's under control. So I can have this with me also.

Students: And you've been doing it for four and a half years. Do you think you're still challenged in this job?

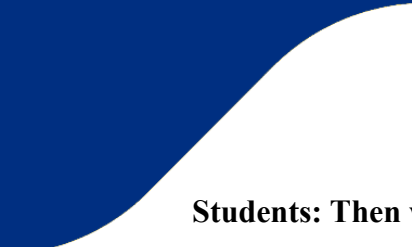
Manager: No, that's why I got the other job. So that's the first part. And well, finally, I would like to have a director position afterwards, if it's possible.

Students: And do you think it is more in the marketing side, the commercial side or more in the HRM side?

Manager: It could be both.

Students: So you said you're four and a half years in this position. At first, what challenges did you face? You say now it's all good. But at first did you have difficulties with anything regarding your position?

Manager: In the beginning, it was a difficult job, yes, because of the problems in the market with vacancies. There were a lot of vacancies and not a lot of people who wanted to work, so in the beginning it was very hard



Students: Then what do you think changed and things became easier?

Manager: Because you get used to it. You put all your marketing experience here, hop on the floor, and then you get used to it and find a way to work with it, and then it's all good. And then you can have a second job with it. That's how it goes.

Students: Okay. We're done. Thank you very much for your time.